



NEERJA BIRLA

52, FOUNDER & CHAIRPERSON, ADITYA BIRLA EDUCATION TRUST

Destiny's Child

BY HER OWN admission, Neerja Birla's professional journey is not typical. "I did not plan for things to move in a particular way; it has all unfolded organically," she says. Take the case of Aditya Birla World Academy, where she wanted to start a school to provide holistic education instead of the more prevalent academic approach. "What also planted the idea in my mind was that I hadn't been able to complete my undergraduate education. I knew how education at that level worked, and I could train the mind to take the right decisions and handle pressure."

Likewise, mental health initiative Mpower had its own genesis. "It was born out of my daughter's bad patch. Even with

money and educated minds, the problem was difficult to solve," she recalls. "I was at my wits' end. After a personal experience, you get more devoted to a cause, which is how Mpower was born." Ananya, her oldest child, asked her to "just do it" at 3 am. Then she contacted the doctors and others involved in the initiative to begin. After so many years, people still look down upon mental health issues. "Questions on whether they will cope with a professional career are asked." That is of concern to her. "The perception that productivity and mental illness can't coexist has to change. That is the goal for Mpower and continues to be so." **BT**

— **BY KRISHNA GOPALAN**

WHAT KEEPS ME GOING

Being able to help people and impact lives positively

A LIFE LESSON LEARNT ON THE JOB

Don't presume the other person can fill in the blanks

EXPANSION MODE

AMID A CHALLENGING business environment marred by subdued consumer demand, a volatile commodities market and geopolitical unrest in key markets, Nisaba Godrej has not only led Godrej Consumer Products Ltd (GCPL) on a growth trajectory, but also made some bold moves. Godrej—who is a part of BT's Most Powerful Women in Business list in 2023—has spearheaded

—deodorants and sexual wellness—but also offers a multi-decadal double-digit sales growth opportunity. The deal has also boosted the company's fortunes at the bourses, with its market capitalisation jumping beyond the ₹1 lakh crore mark for the first time in 2023.

But despite the tough overall operating environment, Godrej has continued to lead GCPL to deliver high single-digit

WHY SHE MATTERS

Heading one of the largest home-grown consumer goods companies in India, Nisaba Godrej is one of a handful of top women leaders in the industry

the acquisition of two popular brands, Park Avenue and KamaSutra, from Raymond Group. The ₹2,825-crore deal not only marks the Godrej Group's foray into two rapidly growing categories

growth in its top line in the first half of FY24. Its operating revenues have surged 8.2 per cent to ₹6,986 crore between April and September, as international markets delivered sales growth in the mid-teens (in constant currency terms). To augment its performance in the domestic market, the company is now looking to strengthen its presence in south India, with a new plant in Tamil Nadu with a capital investment of ₹515 crore. **BT**

— **BY ARNAB DUTTA**



NISABA GODREJ

45, EXECUTIVE CHAIRPERSON, GODREJ CONSUMER PRODUCTS